

Vartika Joshi: We started with some theoretical courses on navigation, communication and weather prediction. Classroom courses are different from sailing outside. So, we were given hands-on training, like, how to repair things and how to deal with emergencies, when the weather gets rough, if there is a medical emergency, and training was needed in tactical aspects as well.

Aishwarya: We underwent our basic sail training courses in Mumbai at the Indian Naval Waterman ship Training Centre (INWTC), and at various schools in the southern naval base in Kochi. We even sailed on INSV Mhadei to Mauritius (in 2016 and 2017) and back and also to Cape Town in December 2016. We were trained for almost three years to prepare for the voyage. Since the boat was old, it had minor leaks and repairs. Also, we ran out of water and food soon. So the trip was a tutorial for us on how to manage food, water and even electricity during the big voyage.

Interviewer: What was the selection process?

Aishwarya: Out of the thirty women who had applied, six of us were shortlisted, based on the little survival skills we showcased. The crew was mentored by Commander Dilip Donde. But after I was told about the flare-ups at sea, I even had second thoughts about joining the team.

Interviewer: How did your family members react when you told them about this expedition?

Vartika Joshi: Our families did have a hard time, but that was because most of them had never even seen the sea! Four of us are from the mountains. The first time my parents saw the ocean was when I invited them to visit. But once they saw that we're doing well and looking after ourselves, they were quite supportive. They were apprehensive and supportive too.

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